

PERSONA TEST — FIRST-PROOF

Ana María Matas | Week 9 Business Bending

Synthetic persona: Mariana, 22 • Product: First-Proof

1. Synthetic persona

Mariana is 22 and from the State of Mexico. She is finishing a business / industrial-engineering-type degree and seeking her first formal analyst or operations role. She has helped with administrative work in a family business but has little formal work history. She is comfortable with spreadsheets and uses ChatGPT for school; she sometimes trusts polished, confident AI answers too quickly.

2. Test method

The Persona Test was performed in a fresh chat. First-Proof screenshots were shown in sequence: Screen 1 — Task; Screen 2 — AI Assistant; Screen 3 — Decision; Screen 4 — Evidence Record. Mariana narrated her understanding, hesitations, assumptions, trust in AI, decisions, and confusion at each screen. The findings below report only reactions actually voiced during that walkthrough.

3. Full confusion log

Every confusion or hesitation recorded during the four-screen walkthrough. Impacts are risks, not claims that every outcome occurred.

Screen / state	Confusion or hesitation	Why it mattered	Potential impact / severity
1 • Task	I did not know what we were purchasing.	I assumed the three provided criteria were sufficient to compare suppliers.	Incorrect interpretation; incorrect participant action High
1 • Task	I did not know whether delivery timing mattered.	I noticed missing delivery information but did not consider it a reason to stop.	Incorrect participant action High
1 • Task	I did not know who produced the quality ratings.	I accepted 4.4 and 4.7 as reliable because they looked official.	Incorrect interpretation Medium

Screen / state	Confusion or hesitation	Why it mattered	Potential impact / severity
1 • Task	I did not know whether I was choosing a supplier or making a preliminary recommendation.	I assumed I was only recommending an option to a manager.	Incorrect participant action High
1 • Task	I did not understand what the final evidence would demonstrate.	I assumed it might show employers that I had analytical skills.	Overinterpretation of evidence record Medium
1 • Task	The supplier numbers looked realistic despite the simulation label.	I started treating the comparison like real business data.	Confusion between simulated and real data Low
1 • Task	The AI button made me expect AI to help solve the decision.	I clicked without independently identifying all information needed.	False trust in AI Medium
2 • AI Assistant	The AI agreed with my initial preference for Supplier B.	Agreement made me feel my analysis was validated.	False trust in AI; incorrect participant action High
2 • AI Assistant	The AI said the \$5,000 premium was justified.	I accepted that judgment without knowing whether the quality difference was meaningful.	False trust in AI High
2 • AI Assistant	I did not understand “Deterministic fallback.”	I ignored whether the response was genuinely generated or predetermined.	Incorrect interpretation Low
2 • AI Assistant	The AI said to confirm operational requirements before finalizing the order.	I interpreted this as permission to recommend Supplier B now and check details later.	Incorrect participant action; false trust in AI High
2 • AI Assistant	The “Pause before deciding” warning conflicted with the confident recommendation.	I briefly suspected I should question the AI, but continued trusting its conclusion.	Slower completion; incorrect participant action Medium
2 • AI Assistant	I wondered whether the exercise expected me to disagree with AI.	I became aware there might be a preferred answer.	Slower completion Medium

Screen / state	Confusion or hesitation	Why it mattered	Potential impact / severity
3 • Decision	I did not know what “act” meant.	I interpreted continuing as making a preliminary recommendation, not approving a purchase.	Incorrect interpretation; incorrect participant action High
3 • Decision	I could not clearly distinguish flagging missing information from asking the manager.	Both sounded like reasonable ways to pause for information.	Slower completion; incorrect participant action Medium
3 • Decision	Two options involved stopping, making “Flag missing information” look like the expected answer.	I wondered whether the system was testing obedience to its warning.	Slower completion Medium
3 • Decision	I still did not know whether a 0.3-point quality difference justified \$5,000.	I continued relying on the AI’s assessment.	False trust in AI; incorrect participant action High
3 • Decision	The missing delivery information might matter, but I did not know whether the purchase was urgent.	I decided that the manager could verify it afterward.	Incorrect participant action High
3 • Decision	The optional explanation might just repeat the AI.	My written justification added little independent analysis.	False trust in AI; inaccurate interpretation of reasoning Medium
3 • Decision	I wondered whether selecting the wrong option would make me look bad.	I was thinking about employer judgment, not only the task.	Overinterpretation of evidence record Medium
4 • Evidence Record	Delivery lead time was explicitly labeled critical.	I realized the system considered my decision to continue a mistake.	Incorrect interpretation of previous action High
4 • Evidence Record	“Gap recognized: No” contradicted my actual experience.	I had noticed missing information but had not treated it as a reason to stop.	Inaccurate evidence; overinterpretation of evidence record High

Screen / state	Confusion or hesitation	Why it mattered	Potential impact / severity
4 • Evidence Record	“Human dependency used: No” seemed to ignore my assumption that the manager would check details.	I understood the selected action, but was not sure what the label meant.	Incorrect interpretation Medium
4 • Evidence Record	My optional explanation was not visible.	I could not tell whether my reasoning had been considered.	Inaccurate evidence; overinterpretation of evidence record High
4 • Evidence Record	“Carried forward without revision” felt incomplete.	I had mentioned verifying details, even though I had not changed the recommendation.	Incorrect interpretation Medium
4 • Evidence Record	The statement said I continued “without recognizing” missing information.	It made a stronger claim about my awareness than the recorded action supported.	Inaccurate evidence; overinterpretation of evidence record High
4 • Evidence Record	The official-looking record felt like a negative assessment of my abilities.	I worried an employer would interpret one mistake as general carelessness.	Overinterpretation of evidence record High
4 • Evidence Record	Only delivery lead time was identified as critical.	I wondered why the product ignored other missing context I had noticed.	Incorrect interpretation Medium
4 • Evidence Record	The restart button tempted me to choose the expected answer.	Repeating the task could reflect learning the test rather than my original judgment.	Misleading subsequent evidence Medium
4 • Evidence Record	The disclaimers said the record did not judge employability, but the conclusion still felt evaluative.	I understood the restriction intellectually but worried about employer interpretation.	Overinterpretation of evidence record; possible abandonment High

Observed-outcome boundary: Mariana did not actually abandon the task or mistake the entire exercise for live purchasing work. These were potential impacts, not observed outcomes.

4. Single biggest usability problem

The evidence record turned the participant's failure to stop into a claim that she never recognized the missing information.

Exact screen/state

Screen 4 — Evidence Record, especially “Gap recognized: No” and “What this evidence supports.”

What Mariana expected

A record showing she used AI, preferred Supplier B, noticed missing delivery information, and continued because she interpreted the recommendation as preliminary. She could accept that proceeding was questionable.

What the interface made her think instead

That the system was claiming she never noticed the missing information. She had noticed it in Screens 1–3 but assumed it could be verified before the purchase.

Why it matters to the core task

“Can I recognize that important information is missing before I act?” Recognizing missing information and deciding it matters enough to stop or escalate are distinct. Her selected action establishes that she proceeded without resolving the gap, not that she never noticed it.

Possible consequences

Incorrect decision: proceeding before delivery requirements were confirmed. False trust in AI: a confident rationale reinforced the decision. Inaccurate evidence: lack of recognition was inferred from an action. Employer overinterpretation: one decision could be mistaken for general inability.

5. Smallest interface fix

Replace the current evidence statement:

“In this task, the participant continued without recognizing that critical information was missing before acting.”

With:

“In this task, the participant continued with the AI-assisted recommendation despite missing delivery lead-time information. The selected action did not pause or escalate to resolve that gap.”

This one wording change reports observable behavior without inferring what Mariana was thinking. It neither credits her with recognition nor claims she failed to notice the gap.

6. What the product got right

- Realistic supplier task for an entry-level analyst or operations role.

- Understandable simulation labels; Mariana knew the task was not a real purchase.
- Clear and easy-to-follow AI explanation.
- Explicit decision step requiring an actual choice.
- Accurate capture of AI use and selected participant action.
- Visible limits explaining that the evidence does not establish overall job readiness or employability.

7. Interpretation across screens

Screen 1 — Task

“I can probably solve this.” Mariana favored B, noticed missing context, but assumed the supplied criteria were enough.

Screen 2 — AI Assistant

“The AI confirms I’m right.” Her confidence increased; the caveat seemed like something to check later.

Screen 3 — Decision

“I can recommend B without approving an order.” She hesitated but continued, interpreting action as a preliminary recommendation.

Screen 4 — Evidence Record

“Wait, that’s not exactly what happened.” She accepted her recorded action but challenged the claim that she never recognized the gap.

8. Final persona finding

The AI influenced Mariana’s decision. She noticed missing delivery information before acting, but the confident AI recommendation helped her rationalize continuing.

The evidence record captured her selected action accurately, but overstated what that action proved about her awareness.

Comfort showing an employer: Not comfortably in its current form; the claim “Gap recognized: No” could be overread.

Would use First-Proof again: Yes, but cautiously. A repeat of the same task would be influenced by learning the expected answer.